The highest decision-making body of the WTO is the Ministerial Conference, which has to meet at least once every two years. It brings together all members of the WTO, all of which are countries or separate customs territories. The Ministerial Conference can take decisions on all matters under any of the multilateral trade agreements. Since the coming into being of the WTO in January 1995, eight Ministerial Conferences have been held, namely, ***Geneva*** (December 15–17, 2011); ***Geneva*** (30 November 30–2, December 2009); ***Hong Kong*** (December 13–18, 2005); ***Cancún*** (September 10–14, 2003); ***Doha*** (November 9–13, 2001); ***Seattle*** (November 30 – December 3, 1999); ***Geneva*** (May 18–20, 1998); ***Singapore*** (December 9–13 1996). The next (9th) Ministerial Conference will be ***Bali*** (December 3–6, 2013).

WTO NEGOTIATIONS AND INDIA

The Doha Round of trade negotiations in the WTO, effectively, made very little progress after 2008. Throughout 2009 and 2010, discussions continued but no headway was made on any substantive issue in the negotiations. However, the subject featured on the agenda of almost every major international meeting and there were strong affirmations of political support for an early conclusion of the Doha Round. Discussions continued in Geneva during March and April 2011, in a variety of formats. Reports on each area of the negotiations were issued on April 21, 2011. These documents provided an overview of the status of negotiations covered in the Doha Development Agenda. While they indicated significant progress in many areas, they also captured the wide gaps remaining on many issues.

The focus then shifted to the possibility of selecting some issues for finalisation as an ***'early harvest'*** in time for the Eighth Ministerial Conference of the WTO in December 2011. It began with an attempt to select issues of particular importance to least developed countries (LDCs). However, these attempts did not meet with any success and proved not only unproductive but very divisive as well. Members could not agree on the issues to be included and sought to selectively bring in various issues of commercial interest to them. Gradually, as members brought in non-LDC